

Mains Master Program 2024: Art and Culture (GS1)

Handout 5: Religion and Philosophy

Q. Compare the Harappan religion with that of the Vedic Aryans. Do you find any similarity?

The distinct socio-economic background of Harappan and Vedic civilizations, one as urban while other as rural, shaped their religious outlook. However, interestingly, some amount of similarity is also visible between the two.

Similarities	Differences
- Both are polytheistic in nature. Harappans worshiped various gods as can be seen from terracotta and stone sculptures while multiple Vedic gods are mentioned in the texts. - In both, there cult of male as well as female goddess was present. - Certain animals treated as sacred in both religions: bull in Harappan while cow/horse in Vedic. Sacrificial rituals were present in both. Fire altars are found in Lothal and Kalibanga, while Vedas talk about various types of daily as well as grand sacrifices.	- While female deities were prominent in Harappa, in Vedic era, there was a primacy of male deities. - The practice of idol worship was very common in Harappa while in the Vedic era, despite descriptions of anthropomorphic deities, idol worship was absent. - While the fertility cult is present in both, its manifestation is quite different. In case of Harappa, it is mostly through some idols and female deities while in case of Rigveda, its through certain rituals. - In Harappan civilization, the cult was sacrifice was not as dominant as in the case of Vedic. - In Harappa, bhakti might have been present which is generally associated with idol worship but in Vedic era, the element of Bhakti seems absent.

Thus, although the nature of both religions is something different, it is equally true that both cultures merged in the mainstream of Indian civilization later and became part of Hinduism in future.

Q. Even after the decline of the Harappan civilization, its legacy is clearly visible in Indian culture. Comment.

Traditionally, it was believed that Harappan civilization met a sudden death but now it is widely believed that the decline was rather gradual. Even though the urban phase declined, some of its cultural practices survived in the form of village cultures. Many Harappan cultural elements are visible in Indian culture even after the thousands of years.

Interconnectedness due to dependency of Harappans on surrounding village cultures transferred some of the skills and knowledge to the contemporary chalcolithic cultures, which survived afterwards. During the **gradual migration from the core** region due to the Harappan decline toward periphery, Harappan people themselves carried some practices. Immediate **cultural succession in the same region by Vedic Aryans** also contributed to continuation of Harappan heritage.

- In the **technological domain**,
 - Potter's wheel, spread of cartwheel
 - Employment of metallurgical techniques like copper smelting and lost-wax
 - Continued use of decimal and hexadecimal system until very recently.

However, it is in the domain of cultural heritage, the imprint of Harappan culture is more clearly visible.

- **Daily life:**
 - Sanitation and personal hygiene
 - Possibly games like chess, dice cube etc.
- **Religion:**
 - Nature worship, animal cult, tree cult (peepal worship), serpent cult, fire cult
 - Worship of mother goddess – shakambari, male gods like Pashupat Shiva
 - Cult practices like use of amulet/talisman, significance of swastika symbol
 - Water cult, Holy dip (similar to Great Bath at Mohenjodaro)
- **Art:**
 - Plastic arts – human and animal figurines
 - Terracotta sculpture
 - Bronze sculpture: Dhokra art in Telangana is practised using lost-wax method

Above all, it was the **cosmopolitan and egalitarian** outlook of Harappans that has been cherished throughout the history of India.

Practice Question

Q. Underline the significance of Vedic civilization in Indian culture.

Q. The Upanishadic principles embody the epitome of Vedic thought. Discuss.

The very term Vedana, used for Upanishads, means epitome of Vedic knowledge. Upanishads represent a shift in emphasis within the Vedic tradition. They move away from external rituals and worship of deities for material gains. The focus is rather on profound metaphysical and philosophical inquiry for pursuit of spiritual liberation.

Gradual Evolution: Though the Samhitas are the collection of hymns (Mantra) to be chanted during the performance of various sacrifices and the Brahmana texts outline the procedures of such performances, both these classes of texts embody sufficient philosophical speculations which are further systematized in the Upanishads. In a sense, the dawn of Indian philosophy may be traced to the Samhitas and the Brahmanas which gradually culminated in the Aranyakas and the Upanishads which resulted in partial replacement of Vedic rituals by meditations and self-knowledge.

- Upanishads explore the nature of reality, nature of existence, the self (**atman**), and the ultimate truth (**brahman**). Thus, from early polytheism and kernel of monotheism, they focus on **monism**, the highest ideal.
- To avoid rebirth, they suggest a path to realization and achieve moksha - which is more of **knowledge** than of karma. This is a key theme in the Vedas as well, but the Upanishads take it to a new level. They argue that knowledge of the self and of Brahman is the **key to liberation**.
- Although **meditation** is found in the Vedas, but the Upanishads give it a new importance. They argue that meditation is the way to achieve direct knowledge of the self and of Brahman.
- The speculations about the **origin of universe** are much more profound in nature. The open speculation of Nasadiya Sukta is taken to deeper analysis in various Upanishads.
- The Upanishads often present their teachings in the form of **dialogues and discourses**, encouraging inquiry and critical thinking. This method of philosophical exploration reflects a sophisticated and open-ended approach to understanding truth, characteristic of mature intellectual traditions.
- They are not only focused on metaphysics. They also provide insights into the **theory of conscience** and also **ethical/moral living**. The shift from ritual karma to dharmic life is clearly distinct in Upanishads.

Thus, Upanishads encapsulate the highest philosophical and spiritual teachings found within the Vedas.

OR

Thus, in the Samhitas and the Brahmanas, the search for the Truth by looking within had begun, the essential unity of god and man was acknowledged. Still the religion was primarily sacrifice centred, ritualistic and originally polytheistic. In the Upanishadic period we find that ritualistic part of religion was relegated to a lesser important position and solving the cosmic mystery and realization of the Atman - Brahman through meditation and renunciation became the central concern.

Q. Discuss the significance of Vedic religion to the modern world.

The Vedic religion, which dates to the 1500 BCE to 500 BCE, not only laid the foundation of many aspects of Indian culture and philosophy that persist today but also provides age-old wisdom into the individual and social aspects of human nature, which are relevant to the modern world.

- Many of the practices and beliefs in modern Hinduism are rooted in the Vedic tradition. Vedas and Upanishads contain **profound philosophical wisdom**.
 - Concepts such as **Dharma, Karma, and Moksha** continue to inspire seekers today, who try to make **sense of the chaos in the modern world**.
 - The **philosophy of the Upanishads**, which emphasizes the **unity of all things (Advaita Vedanta)** helps in creating **holistic approach to life**.
- **Spiritual Pluralism:** Vedas accept diverse beliefs and practices, which resonates with the contemporary emphasis on religious tolerance, diversity, mutual accommodation, coexistence, openness, and interfaith dialogue and thus promotes a harmonious society.
- **Social and Ethical Values:** Vedic religion emphasizes principles of **non-violence, compassion, respect for all beings, and the interconnectedness of life**. These ethical values remain relevant in addressing contemporary challenges, such as social justice, and harmony among diverse communities.
- The basic tenets of **social equality** were present in the Vedic Society.
 - Even though the Vedic society was a patriarchal society, the **condition of women** was much better compared to the latter ages. Due to this reason, many modern reformers of the 19th century had accepted the Vedic age as an ideal model for society.
- **Social Cohesion:** The tribal community of Vedic era focussed on reducing internal feuds and having harmonious social relations, which can also be seen as important value in the 21st century when social fragmentation is becoming more normal.
- **Yoga**, which has become increasingly popular for improving physical and mental health, is rooted in Vedic religion.
- **Environmental Consciousness:** The Vedic hymns prays various natural forces as deities, emphasize interconnectedness of all living beings and the sanctity of nature. In the Anthropocene era, when environmental concerns are becoming graver, such Vedic view helps in sustainable living and ecological preservation.

Thus, the ancient-yet-living tradition of Vedic religion encodes certain eternal values which are useful for both individual and society at the larger level in the 21st century.

Q. "Gautama Buddha was a social reformer, a revolutionary who stood against social discrimination and favoured equality for all." Examine.

In the background of increased complexities of Vedic rituals, social discrimination on grounds of Varna and Jati, Urbanization and emergence of new social groups like Sethis and Gahpatis, the sixth century BCE saw the emergence of many heterodox sects like Buddhism, Jainism, Ajivikas etc.

Among these, the key ideas of Buddhism, and the teachings of its founder- Gautama Buddha were seen as promoting social equality. He questioned the existing religious and social structure of the time. As he raised the fundamental questions, he received wider acceptance outside of India as well. Basic issues like religious ritualism were highlighted, caste system was attacked, shown sensitivity to women.

- The Buddhist monks accepted food from everyone, **regardless of class or caste**. The Pali Canon also rejects the highest status accorded to Brahmins in the texts. The Buddhist Sangha allowed people from lower social orders to become monks, participate in studies and achieve salvation. Thus, in Buddhism, **Varna or Jati was irrelevant for the spiritual pursuit**.
- **The position of women** under Buddhism was also better. They could become nuns, participate in studies and work towards achievement of salvation.

Thus, Buddha was seen as a revolutionary and a great social reformer. But at the same time, deeper analysis of Buddhist text presents existence of several forms of social discrimination in Buddhism.

- **Slaves, debtors, serving soldiers** etc were not allowed to join Sanghas.
- Thus, although he attacked the **caste system**, he couldn't give a substitute. Rather, a large number of Monks in Sanghas were from 'Uchcha Kula' i.e. Brahmins or Kshatriyas. In Pali canon, rather than going for end of varna system in society, there is a reversal of the Brahmanical order of rank. Kshatriyas are given higher status than that of Brahmins.
- Followers of Buddha also had a **notion of high and low status**. Vinaya Pitaka mentions that occupations like accounting, writing etc were considered high occupations whereas leather works, tailor, reed making etc were considered low occupation.
- Although he allowed possibility of Nirvana and admission to Sangha to **women**, women were not given complete equality. Initial hesitation of Buddha to allow women to join Sanghas, extra condition and restriction imposed on nuns etc. militated against women.

All these indicate that Buddhism was not completely egalitarian and some discrimination on the basis of background, occupation or gender existed. Thus, although a great reformer, not a radical thinker as he didn't break sharply with the past.

Q. How far was Buddhism inspired by the ideas of Upanishads? Explain.

Upanishads and Buddhism, both were the product of the socio-economic change in India (second urbanization), and both have common economic-social milieu.

- Both were equally **opposed to the Vedic sacrifices**.
- The concepts of **rebirth** and **some forms of karma** are accepted by both Buddhism and Upanishadic thought. Both traditions **value the renunciant lifestyle** and seek liberation from the cycle of birth and death.
- Both traditions recognize the **importance of ethical conduct**, such as compassion, charity, and moral improvement.
- **Vegetarianism** and **non-violence** towards animals is promoted in both Buddhist and Upanishadic ideas. Both gave support to the agrarian economy, and **both discouraged the slaughter of animals**.
- **Personal experience** and **direct realisation** are emphasised in both traditions.

But there is other side of picture as well.

- Where the **Upanishads had reformative approach** to Vedic religion to make it better, **Buddhism took the radical approach**. It rejected the Vedic religion altogether.
 1. Upanishads talk about the supreme soul **Brahman**, and the relationship between **Atman and Brahman**. However, Buddhism rejected both Atman and Brahma.
- Buddhism promoted renunciation without considering **varna**, whereas the Upanishads maintained the varna system and prescribed specific stages of life for renunciation.
- The Buddha's teachings focus on the **middle path** and the elimination of attachment as a cause of suffering, while the Upanishads emphasise following dharma and attaining good karma.
- Buddhism spread through **conversion** and **proselytism**, while the Upanishads are silent on the issue of religious conversion.

Thus, although inspired, yet major departure too.

Q. Decline of Buddhism was a complex process with various factors. Elaborate.

Decline of Buddhism in the post-Gupta era was a gradual process due to various internal as well as external factors.

1. Internal Factors:

- **Corruptions in Buddhist Sanghas:** In course of time, luxurious monastic life lead to indiscipline. Sanghas with large land grants focused on material pursuits.
- **Sangha Division:** Splinter groups led to loss of originality. Simplicity of Early Buddhism was lost as doctrines became complex. Influence of Tantrism made it less accessible.
- **Use of Sanskrit Language:** Simple Pali was replaced by complex Sanskrit language. So, few people were able to understand it.
- **Uninspiring Leadership:** Absence of dynamic preachers and reformers compared earlier examples of Ananda, Sariputta and Maudgalayana.
- **Buddha Worship:** Mahayana Buddhism started worshipping the Buddha image (unlike original teaching) which made Buddhism look like Hinduism.

2. Revival of Hinduism:

- **Adi Shankaracharya** revived and strengthened Hinduism. He defeated Buddhist scholars in religious discourses in course of his tour of the whole of India.
- With the beginning of **Puranic Hinduism**, the rituals were simplified, popular languages were adopted, Buddhist principles (eg non-violence) were **assimilated**, and Buddha was accepted as a Vishnu incarnation.
- **Devotional Hinduism** became more popular among the common people while monastic Buddhism got disconnected from public life.

3. External Causes:

- **Beginning of feudalism:** With the fragmentation of central power, reduction in trade and rise of regional Rajput powers (like Chauhans, Gurjaras, Solankis etc) royal support shifted towards other communities.
- **Loss of Royal Patronage:** After Harsha, patronage shifted to Shaivism and Vaishnavism (except for Pala era)
- **External Invasions:** Huna kings like Toamana and Mihirakula killed the Buddhists residing in the north-western part of India. While Bakhtiyar Khilji destroyed the great Viharas of Nalanda and Odantapuri.

Thus, the decline of Buddhism in the post-Gupta era was a complex process with multiple factors and forces at work.

Q Buddha's teachings, to a great extent, could be helpful in understanding and resolving the challenges in modern society. Discuss

Buddhism tried to address some fundamental human questions about human existence. Therefore, some of the Buddhist ideas remain relevant for all time to come.

OR

Buddhist ideas deal with the core human values and psychological make-up. Therefore, they are also relevant in the modern era characterised by fast change, technological disruption, social upheavals and value confusion.

- Non-violence (Ahimsa)
- Desire (Tanha) and Detachment
- Middle path (Majjhima magga)
- Rationalism
- Ethical conduct (shila)
- Compassion (karuna)
- Democratic spirit
- Denial of soul and brahma (anatta and anicca)
- Buddhism was not simply a religious reform but also a social reform.
- Buddhist meditation

Thus, ideas and principles of Buddha can be guiding light to make the world better for today and tomorrow.

Practice Question

Q. Assess the importance of Jain tenets and their relevance to humanity.

Practice

Q. Is Ashoka's policy of Dhamma relevant in the present era?

Q. During Post-Maurya period, Bhakti brought new vigour and vitality to existing religions.

During Early Christian centuries, religion underwent a major transformation as a result of which it developed certain features which can be easily identified with Hinduism. As a result of intermixing of Aryans and non-Aryans, following features appeared in the field of religion:

- There was the development of **Bhakti** as a mode of worship. It led to the development of various sects in every religion. (Vaishnavism, Shaivism, Mahayana etc)
 1. Vaishnavism and Shaivism
 2. In Buddhism there was a rise of Mahayana devotionalism with Bodhisattva at the centre.
 3. In Jainism, the worship of Tirthankar became norm.
- To assimilate non-Aryan elements into Aryan, the concept of **avataravada** was promoted.
 1. Thus, Vishnu had dashavatara while Shaivism also believed 21/24 re-incarnations. Both Bodhisattva idea and the idea of 24 Tirthankaras was influenced by that.
 2. Local/folk deities like Yaksha, Yakshi were absorbed all major religions.
- During this period, the practice of **idol worship** became mainstay in every religion.
 1. Buddhas murtis started to appear in Gandhara, Mathura and Amaravati.
 2. Iconographic conventions were created for depiction of various Brahmanical as well as Jain deities in Mathura.
- In social domain, there was arrival of various **foreigners** to India (Indo-Greeks, Shakas, Kushanas etc). On one hand, the openness of Indian religions allowed them to be embraced and **Indianized**. On the other hand, due to socio-political upheaval, there was also a rise of religious-social texts like **Manusmriti** in this era, which laid down **rigid social norms**.

Q. Puranas were the innovative genre of literature to popularise and revive Vedic religion. Elaborate.

The emergence of second urbanization and the rise of heterodox sects after the 6th c. BCE posed a significant challenge to Vedic religion. The central institution of the Vedic religion, the yajna faced criticism for being exclusive and complex. In response, the Puranic literature played a crucial role in popularising and reviving Vedic religion. Along with epics (Mahabharata and Ramayana), they were more inclusive and accommodated broader audience.

Here are some key aspects illustrate this transformative role of the Puranas:

1. Inclusivity and Accessibility: The Puranas made Vedic teachings accessible to people.

- Unlike the Vedic **rituals** that required specialised knowledge and were confined to the elite, the Puranas propagated the practice of **vratas** and **tirthas**. It extended religious participation to everyone, irrespective of caste or gender.
- The **narrative stories (purana-kathas)** were effective and entertaining medium for conveying religious-moral messages to diverse groups of people.

2. Puranas assimilated local deities and cults into the broader Hindu pantheon.

- While Vedic gods like Indra, Agni, Soma, Vayu, and Surya were glorified, **many non-Vedic gods** also found a place in Puranic literature. This inclusivity helped **integrate various regional and tribal beliefs and locations** into mainstream Hinduism.

- Now, the **Trimurti** of Brahma (the creator), Vishnu (the preserver), and Shiva (the destroyer) became central figures in Puranic literature, overshadowing the earlier Vedic gods.
 - E.g. **Vishnu Purana** emphasises the worship of Vishnu and narrates stories of various avatars. **Brahma Purana** blends of mythological narratives and geographical descriptions, thus integrating various local sacred centres.
3. The transition from the elaborate Vedic yajna to more **accessible forms of worship such as puja**:
- Puja of an image/murti could be performed in permanent temples accessible to a broader range of devotees. Thus, more people to participate in religious activities.
4. Puranas also gradually **incorporated elements from heterodox traditions**.
- For example, initially, Tantrism, which did not recognize the infallibility of the Vedas, was condemned by the Puranas. However, over time, Tantric elements became noticeable in Puranic texts.
5. Beyond religious content, the Puranas contained **secular knowledge**, including political history, cultural intermingling, land grant systems, and concepts of time. This **broad scope of content** helped the Puranas appeal to a wide audience. They could transmit knowledge and cultural values easily.
- E.g. **Agni Puran** provides comprehensive information on a wide range of topics, including rituals, cosmology, law, politics, and medicine, illustrating the inclusive and encyclopaedic nature of Puranic literature.

Thus, Puranas were innovative not just in their content but in their approach to religious and social inclusivity. Their adaptability and inclusiveness ensured that the core tenets of Vedic religion could endure and thrive in the changing social and religious landscape of ancient India.

Q. Discuss the ways in which the Bhakti movement expressed criticism of the caste system.

The Bhakti movement, which tried to establish a personal emotional bond between devotees and their gods on a religious plain, was also a movement for social reform. It challenged the rigid social hierarchy and caste discrimination while emphasizing the importance of personal devotion.

Expression of criticism of the caste system:

- Bhakti saints **criticized the elaborate/external rituals and monopoly of Brahmins**. Instead, they advocated personal devotion and assured access to God without an intermediary.
 - For example, Kabir's monotheism.
- Bhakti saints taught that all people are equal in the eyes of God. (**spiritual equality**)
 - For example, Vallabhacharya and Chaitanya Mahaprabhu taught that bhakti is open to all people by saying, "The caste of a devotee is devotion itself."
- The Bhakti saints emphasized that **devotional qualities were more important than one's birth/caste** or ritual status. By saying that everyone can attain salvation, irrespective of caste, they **democratized the religion**.
 - Sant Namdev: "I am a weaver by caste, but I am a devotee of Krishna. Why should I be denied entry into the temple?"
- Many Bhakti **saints, such as Kabir and Ravidas, were themselves from lower castes** and engaged in occupations traditionally considered impure. Their example challenged the discriminatory caste norms.

- Bhakti saints disregarded social norms and **interacted with people from various castes**, including untouchables.
 - Guru Nanak frequently travelled with Mardana who came from the 'lower' caste of Mirasi (a community of dancers and singers).
- In their poems, Bhakti saints often **imagined a welfare state giving equal and just treatment** to people of all castes.
 - Basavanna threatened the caste hierarchy and worked for 'Kalyan Rajya' (Welfare State) for all.
 - Ravidas spoke of the need for a casteless society.
- **Use of regional/vernacular languages** made the message of the bhakti saints more accessible to the common masses who were denied access to Sanskrit education.
 - Eg. Guru Nanak composed in Punjabi while Tukaram in Marathi and Meera in Braja bhasha.

Thus, the Bhakti movement, as a social movement, significantly criticized the caste system and promoted the ideals of spiritual and social equality. Its lasting impact on Indian society can be felt even in the modern time.

OR

Thus, the approach of these saints was broadly humanistic. They emphasized broad human values like love and beauty in all their forms, and even today, they inspire and guide Indian society.

Q. Bhakti and Sufi movements were "two aspects of the same religious quest." Explain.

Introductions:

- Bhaktism and Sufism emerged as parallel and mutually interacting devotional movements in the medieval India.
- Although Bhakti originated within the Hindu religious framework and Sufism emerged within the Islamic context, their core religious quest was very similar.
- Despite some outward differences in their theological form, the core philosophical essence of Bhakti and Sufism is very similar.

Similarities:

- **Godhead:**

- Bhakti often focused on **Universal God** in some form (either Advaita Nirguna or Vishnu/Shiva as saguna). Within Sufism, the concept of **Wahad-al-Wajud** came closer to the concept of Nirgun universal idea of **Advaita Vedanta**.

- **Mode:**

- Both Bhakti and Sufi thoughts revolved around a **deep sense of devotion to the divine**. Bhakti emphasized a **emotional connect** with ishta devata, while Sufism focused on attaining spiritual closeness to Allah through **love**. Thus, elements of **complete surrender** and **intense emotion** are present in both.
- Both Bhakti and Sufi **rejected rigid ritualism** and focused on inner spirituality. (eg Beshara silsilahs like qalandars, Nirguni saints like Kabir)

- Both traditions emphasized the importance of **personal experience**. They believed that intellectual understanding alone was insufficient for true spiritual realization.
- Going beyond formal adherence to their religion, both tried to attain **mystical experience** through direct communion with the god.
- Both movements often expressed their ideas through **poetry and music**. Various similar musical community gatherings like raqs, sama and sankirtans were developed.
- **Mutual Interaction:**
 - Both movements interacted and **influenced one another**. Hindu meditative practices were assimilated by Sufism while Islamic monism influenced Bhakti traditions.
- **Similar social worldview:**
 - Neither did all Bhakti saints reject the material world completely nor did all Sufi saints. With respect to **material possessions and family life**, the outlook was equally diverse on both sides: ranging from possession to austerities.
 - Both manifested **an inclusive outlook**. They preached the message of **spiritual equality** regardless of caste, gender, or social status. They taught that all people are equal in the eyes of God.
 - Advocated for **universal brotherhood, love, compassion and humanism** while rejecting sectarianism.
 - Usage of **languages** of common people.

Thus, the distinct religious-cultural-historical factors may have shaped their individual development, resulting in some differences. However, despite these differences, both challenged the authority of the established religions and helped to promote mutual tolerance and harmony.

Practice Question

Q. "Sufis and medieval mystic saints failed to modify either the religious ideas and practices or the outward structure of Islamic/Hindu societies to any appreciable extent." Comment.